

Plaything.

Main Idea:

Retro realistic fighting game based off the vibes of old games like crazy machines, UBfunkeys, 500 caliber contracts, ratchet&clank, Ballance, Garfield 2004, doom, Dinomite, and of course Black magic unleashed.

"When you lose something precious, you..."
"Search for it endlessly."
"Make something new."
"Hope it comes back someday."

"Your favorite kind of toy is..."
"One that never changes."
"One that's soft and familiar."
"One that can transform."

"You see a locked door. You..."
"Remember who locked it."
"Shake the handle, just in case."
"Imagine what's behind it."

"Do you find yourself living in the past, present, or future?"



Story:

There once was someone named "Him", Him was a creator of toys but Him was looked down on by the others around for doing so. Him after being made to feel like nothing by Him's peers and family, Him attempted to destroy the toys but failed. The toys after being infected by Him's agony came to life and inherited parts of Him's personality. Fearful of the new creations, Him locked them away forever, but Him was like a father to them and just continued the cycle and made them feel like nothing.

There were three main toys at the toy who inherited the most: Cairn, pal, and nightshade, all exemplifying different parts of Him's personality but also the coping mechanisms for being made to feel like an object and worthless. Cairn: "Did Him hate us? How can we be perfect?" Pal: "What is our purpose now? Maybe we should've died like Him wanted" Nightshade: "Him was our enemy, we can never be vulnerable ever again."

All three were focused on escaping the prison, only to see Him was gone. With no goal left the looked at each other and finally decided to work together, in a way Him became Them and they could finally come to terms with who they are and their Past, Present, Future, and decide to carry on Him's legacy creating toys, creating friends, creating a family. Cairn: "I don't think I'm okay." Pal: "i don't think I'll ever be okay" Nightshade: "I don't think i want to be okay" Them: "I don't care anymore."

The main Game-play:

A battlegrounds mode with a focus on spectating being just as engaging as actually playing, people can hang out, chat, emote, and even explore if they ever get winded from practicing but still want to keep the streak up.

Everyone starts off in social mode, in this mode your invincible and can explore the map. Press F to enter combat mode, mostly these modes exist so you can decide when or when not to get assaulted by random people looking for a fight.

Most if not all maps have hidden areas for 1v1s so its not always a big death-match if you don't want one, there will also be dummies to practice against in those areas if nobody wants to 1v1.

Player setup and art direction:

Every player wields a sword and a gun and has some orbs floating around them which shows how much mana they have.

Every player has a little icon above their name, usually vague symbols like a merkaba or a metatron's cube or even the typical roblox spawn symbol. This is just a fun aesthetic thing cause I like icons.

Players are completely black and white apart from their accent color which you can choose, this is to maintain good contrast on busy maps and when the game has to change your color for team fights. Your melee weapon are black and your accent color, your gun is white and your accent color, both use their colors for their particle effects so you know which type of move is being used. Your icon, blood, text, are all your accent color.

Materials are extremely important in this game, the character body is basically just a plush toy you can draw onto which was made boxy to make it a better canvas. a jagged silhouette with just the texture of an very backlit ear with hollow eyes is way different if you just remove the blurring cause then its all just a way too visible and clear, texture isn't always about texture but sometimes about feel as-well. Every character should have that feeling, the shine and waves of grass, the glisten and grain of velvet, and yes that weird old school plastic feel that is just ever so slightly off like the very early days of 3d. People care so much about the poly and render count when you can do so much with just fake normal maps, just making your entire player chrome with reflection maps is something every player should be able to enjoy



UI elements:

The main ui is two borders on each side of the screen to create a 4:3 and cinematic feel, on each side is just a few 3d objects like a clock, a heart, and maybe some more on a background. Since they are just 3d objects players can easily move the UI around, the background is usually a scrolling pattern and a moving stereo-gram but can be changed on the fly into basically anything.

Imagine a cross in the middle, with a dot at the end of the lines, now remove the lines and draw a vector from one dot to another (left to right), now curve around the middle (right to up). This is how the keystroke system is visualized, just a two point vector, two inputs per every move. Double taps are not included here because they aren't a vector, so they're reserved for dodges. When a straight vector move is performed it will move in its direction before sitting next to the ui, curved vectors will just radiate from the center in their outward curve direction instead of its arrow direction like straight vector. When that specific vector symbol is on your screen, that move is on cool-down and you need to wait till it fades.

Keystroke and combat system:

The player must hold left click to enter the combat stance and perform a move's keystroke to perform the move, while performing any move you can queue another. You can perform both a melee attack and a projectile attack at a time. Trying to perform another attack while one of the same type is already active will cause it to be queued (only one attack can be queued at a time and dodges can use either slot),

Projectile attacks usually require Orbs to perform and don't hit blocking enemies, weaker ones can be destroyed just by clashing with them using a melee attack. Projectiles are useful for zoning, pressure, combos, and fulfills the role as your burst options when in a bind due to them being usable in hit-stun. Orbs are this games meter system and a max of 4 will hover around your avatar, orbs can be gained when striking an enemy with a melee attack or through the use of some specific moves.

Holding right click will cause you to block and prevent you from getting hit from others attacks unless your hit from behind.

Each hit a player takes in a combo will cause them to take less and less hit-stun, its best to use multi-hits and projectile stacking when in the late part of a combo for max damage.

The game is designed around players having a lot of attacks, each with a purpose. This makes combos very context sensitive allowing for creativity and decision making when players are low on resources, since each attack has a cool-down..

(WA, WS, WD,) (AW, AS, AD,) (SA, SW, SD,) (DA, DS, DW,) (WW, AA, SS, DD,) All attacks or moves are a combination of two buttons pressed in sequence, the buttons usually mirror what range the move has and its movement. Combat moves are locked to opposing cardinal directions, dodges are locked to matching directions in any direction. On keyboard this usually means a double tap of two directions at the same time to dodge diagonally, on analog you have two options. You can choose to go for single stick (Left stick does analog double tap) or double stick (Tap both sticks into an analog direction like tank controls.)

Map ideas:

The loom:

A giant tower that reaches into the sky, with bridges made of wood like ballance and floating primitives. Feels kinda like an ms escher staircase, but in ruin. Old toys still on hooks or stuck under rubble.

The creator got turned against his creations and his creations got turned against him by an idea instilled, maybe one of the toys tried to turn this loom into just a factory to fight back and then the loom sits there destroyed and covered up after the fact, this place of creation that could have been used to help and fix the hurt was used for spite and was destroyed so as the cycle claims another. I kinda like that, cause that makes the loom an in story thing, a footnote. It doesn't have this big important reason for being destroyed, it was a single person, an unimportant person who fucked up, it could be anyone. Maybe some things are best left forgotten, forever.

House fire:

Players start in a basement with a little boiler, if you set yourself on fire and touch the door leading up you can damage it since you can't open it.

When players finish burning down the door it falls with a crash to the floor and starts playing music (winds of fjords in this example), a death clock will also appear at the top and players then get to explore the rest of the house. The death clock is primarily to tell players to get out of the house before the fire from the door (remember that) is spreading and will then burn the house.

The fire spreads along the floor just looking like a simmer, then the death clock ends and there's a bright flash. The house model is swapped to just a frame as the fires intensifies and the music swells, while this happens i want the UI background (that's usually a pattern) swap to real-life clips of stuff burning like photographs and the like, showing game fire next to real video and trying to make them feel as similar as possible should help sell the effect and what exactly is burning. As they look on at the house, the video should be about connect the past that is burning, the present of the warm feeling of the fire, and the future that is opened up to them as they leave it all behind while the melancholic music plays. As the music comes to a hold note at the very end the videos on the background themselves burn and the house comes crashing down, blanketing the entire area in smoke. After a few moments and a smaller version of the melody plays, people can see the sun coming up through the smoke, a new dawn for us all.

Maybe before the house collapses you can see Him, on the horizon like its the "HellValleySkyTree" figures from mario galaxy two. Visible enough to see clearly, but you can't tell of its real or a ghost. The meaning is unclear and how Him feels about it, maybe all it means is that Him is in all of us. It really is your choice how to feel about it, but i think the whole thing should feel pretty special if i can pull off such a thing.

And again, after the fact and the players have seen it. All that they come back to is the ruins, it isn't what happened here it's about the conflicting emotions about it that still bring that mystery. But you can never go back and change it, the past stays where it is. Nothing but memories now.

Mono-chrome:

This area is pale as day, white birch trees with chrome leaves and weird primitive robots litter the area, that have existed here for a long time and seemingly lost their purpose. "Hedges" carved into various shapes litter the landscape, some being players, teapots, and primitive objects. A fountain rests in the middle with many player bushes around it, if you look away it feels like they are moving toward it, reaching for the bringer of life.

On the other side there is a cliff overlooking a big valley below with a large tree a swing-set on said cliff, the moon above is large and fills the sky.

Characters:

Cairn is the character of the past.

They take the form of a colorful cat vase like the vases you create as a kid or that grandparents have, being heated and molded by the past before being set in their ways. They're covered in skin on one of their sides and it's not the skin that's off-putting but rather what it's doing.

Their vase body covered in beautiful markings and scars, but prone to breaking and vandalism due to them wearing their heart on their sleeve. Cairn aims to protect their colorful and fragile self under the protective layers of their mask, to be more loved by the people of the present and future. Because as a vase they cannot be changed without breaking and that's scary, so they preserve their old self underneath but at the same time slashing it and wanting it destroyed and replaced by their mask because they've been made to believe no-one will love them otherwise. The layer isn't perfect at protecting them and no-one will know what's happening underneath, which ends up hurting them even more since they don't know Cairn's needs.

Cairn needs to trust the people around them, that they will be loved in the present even if they aren't modern or strong for the future since they as a person are timeless and perfect. They might crack but they need to trust their friends will be there to fix them, that they make them stronger with new parts and Cairn needs to be able to accept that change for the future. They might change physically and mentally when they show themselves freely but if it's with the people they love they will respect Cairn, and make sure it's for the better and not the worse. They might still shatter and leave this world in the future, but they have accepted that and make the most of the time they have now.

Pal is the character of the present.

They take the form of a yellowing old ruined 90s robotic pet dog toy, they're hurt by the past and have a possible future better than Cairn since they're less fragile and more modern but they're still quite unstable. They were taken advantage of by others in the past and turned into a fighting dog, leaving Pal running from the past and struggling to stay in control of the present while alienating others and being prone to anger with abandonment issues hurting their future.

Because of their past hurt ruining their voice box Pal finds it difficult to communicate their needs to others and make friends, making their future uncertain as a result and leaving them all alone. As their battery leaks it leaves them weaker and worse with communication, without attention or help Pal won't last much longer.

Nightshade is the character of the future.

Before the events of the past even started she was already abandoned, after being made to feel like nothing she relegated herself to pleasing the people around her. But feeling she isn't worthy of happiness or respect she repressed her emotions and needs, leaving her to be unstable and prone to anger. She takes the appearance of a white faceless humanoid bunny covered in mold and purple flowers.

Developer commentary (Stuff I thought was fun enough and important to the games creation I wanted to leave in, there's no order.)

The loom isn't the only idea I've wanted in terms of maps for people to play on, one of the core things i wanted was a house since they're toys but also most retro licensed games benefit from already having that feeling of memory intact since you get to see their house and know them as people through their experiences on the wall. For a while i wasn't sure what i would do with it, do players just get to roam the whole place? where are the people? Eventually i opted to remove the people and lock the toys in the basement cause of the story but it also made unlocking parts of the house and exploring it a bigger part of the game, which again would add to the feeling i want. Still, due to how the game is with cycling maps i always thought it about cycling memories, so each map will have some kind of set-piece (i hope) which will make the whole package feel a lot more special.

Now for the longest time in the game i really wanted something "epic" and i wasn't sure how to naturally put that in, i thought about monsters or cool weapons and while cool weapons will be here and the game will still have a focus on cool materials they don't have much place in the story, they're just here cause they're fun. Monsters was entirely scrapped on multiple occasions, i wanted the game to mostly be infighting again for story reasons but for game-play reasons as-well and so both are interlinked. "Epic" isn't really anything in particular, i always thought of it being this state where you do something with such confidence and conviction that everyone is entranced, usually by playing banger music, i feel music is a HUGE part of how we experience emotions so if you want players to feel a certain way you do kinda have to cheat by just playing the sad music but oh well.

One of these "epic" things ties to that music, some of my favorite music is boss fight music cause if its good it has that amazing way of making you feel a certain way about it. Its looming, scary, its intense, its grand, it's empowering, it makes you go through so many different feelings at once like its the stages of grief, it brings all your senses and feelings to the front, and in a way brings past present and future along for the ride. You're scared for the future, your excited in the present, and then sad for the past when its over, they're all important and they're all here. They were this giant fire golem with a big sword and their deal was that their heart was actually one of the toys, like used for power or something. It was kinda about the parent father relationship how one can feel entitled to their creation but in the MOST EPIC WAY POSSIBLE! IT was cool but it fell flat, i couldn't find a good way to keep them in and justify their existence, so the year of working with his design and modeling got scrapped but i liked the ideas they came with so i pivoting to going all in with it which made realism and the story a higher priority.

So, i had to put all those ideas somewhere and i thought, why not burn the house? Sticks with the theme of fire and having a death clock is a tested formula for making tension especially when it comes out of nowhere. Just escape the house while it burns on a time limit, but that is REALLY out of left field on a battlegrounds game, where would i even put it? I had talks of doing transition cutscenes from going to and from maps or from different game moves, but that simultaneously makes them too out of the way and also too common since they happen when you are trying to do other things and then letting the player skip them if they don't want to see them is just a bandage on the whole issue which brings us to square one. Instead, ill opt for semi client side map events. Like on the basement map there's a furnace you can set yourself on fire it for the funsies but you can also use the fire debuff to burn down the door keeping you in the basement, which would burn everything else. Players who have already done that get access to the whole house after its been burned and can never do it again, if the event happens again by someone triggering it, the event will happen for every player who has not yet done it.

This solves the problem of it being tied to a map, where everyone will intentionally do it to get out of the house, so those players get out of the house automatically since they have already done it and hence experienced players are less likely to spoil the fun and the surprise for others. But there's also the feeling of being left out, pros don't want to talk about it since its one thing they can never experience again.

"On the other side there is a cliff overlooking a big valley below with a large tree a swing-set on said cliff, the moon above is large and fills the sky."

This is imagery I've had in my mind since i drew it in like 4th grade (The school closed my account and amino is dead so its lost media now) and i would really like to do something with it, I'm not sure why its stuck with me but there's something about it. My original idea even back then was the death of childhood (i was an edgy kid i guess), something about the swing-set being the one last thing you genuinely enjoy and the cliff in front of you that calls you forward like its edgy flipnote from 2000 making nyan cat commit suicide. (i actually still have this saved for some reason, priorities i guess it IS pretty funny and it did actually help me when i was younger) In a way i haven't really changed, it was about childhood trauma then and it's still about that now. The game was originally called shards of enamel, (like one of my inspirations shards of genesis) but also that first time you get scolded and inflicted with anxiety when you disappoint your parents by tripping into that vase. Maybe that's what the map count be about? all the hedges of objects, memories into the past that you wish to destroy but the roots keep everything together.

A molded plush with tears plunging a key attached to their head into themselves is thematically resonant because: They're one of those keychain plushies, the key is also that, you know those toys that when you press a button they shut their eyes thats what the idea is, the mold is obvious, and the crying thats a fun part its actually the cut stings of the sewing that held their button eyes in before they fell out i really like that one. All of these things fit together perfectly to tell an obvious metaphor but wouldn't work if they were taken apart and put in different metaphors.

They all are just things that seemingly exist and have no purpose (or is REALLY hard to figure out because their visuals are misleading) but all have AMAZING theming, they look like they are made for a purpose and or are radically of place but just have no obvious distinction to point at. Any structure like this if not taken great care of can usually become a boring futurist fantasy like "ooo cool city in the sky because tech is so cool this is the future!" when really you should be wondering why they would even go through with such a shitty idea that consumes so much energy, they of course never even consider the question but that mystery of "someone was here and why?" is fun because they are solo and nobody else is actively using the area for it to justify its existence. "This thing people tried to keep a mystery is now unveiled and its YOUR duty to unlock its secrets", who knows why?

There's a delicate balance between games that have difficult inputs, and controllers which can directly send inputs and what to do about it. some would ban the controller, but i would argue this is like the case of an issue with the game like piracy being an issue of the service and cheating being an issue with balance and the community being overly competitive.

Like, new razer keyboards allow perfect strafing by just ignoring an input stream while an opposite key is pressed and you know that would be a good thing to have by default, are people really advocating to keep strafing it games is it really fun? This is why i opt for physics based games, it's fundamentally harder to cheat on them due to no hit-scan and no instant movements and keystrokes are so short that it's fundamentally easier to learn them square than to make a macro for 20 moves which is why we did them in the first place.

By optimizing for the foundation that supports our game, these things are necessary for the game-play to exist and are impossible to sidestep during development and extremely difficult to get around when cheating.

A game that is easy to cheat is the exact opposite, something like pong where there is only a single option that is so easy to cheat at that its the baseline standard for making ai play games. Having multiple options isn't just fun, it's important. In an action game a combo is whatever you want, in a fighting game a combo is a string of the exact same moves every single time since cool-downs don't exist so you fundamentally could use a macro here and trivialize it.

Questions and commands: Questions will be answered by a unique npc called Tiffany that walks around on most maps.

Aardvark;squirrel;bear: "I don't think animals exist here..."

Combat: "Press F to enter combat mode and attack players around you who are holding weapons by performing keystrokes!"